

Skidmore, Owings & Merrill

One of the largest architectural firms in the world, Skidmore, Owings & Merrill was formed in Chicago in the 1930s by Louis Skidmore (1897–1962), Nathaniel Owings (1903–84) and John O. Merrill (1896–1975). It has since employed numerous outstanding architects, produced thousands of buildings and products and exerted an important influence on urban planning.

Famous for its inventiveness, the firm has produced a roll-call of world-renowned designs, such as the John Hancock Building in Chicago, a tapered rectangular tube standing 100 storeys tall (see also [here](#)). The Willis or Sears Tower (opposite, 1970–3), also in Chicago, employs the 'bundled tube' system – an innovation from one of the firm's partners, Fazlur Rahman Khan, that has revolutionized tall building design. Comprising a matrix of nine 'tubes' bound together, the Willis Tower was for 25 years the world's tallest skyscraper, a title now held by the firm's 163-storey, 829.8-metre (2,722-ft) Burj Khalifa in Dubai (see [here](#)).

